MESA VALLEY UNIVERSITY

School of Public Health and Health Policy

HPM 635 | Health Policy Analysis and Rural Health Systems

Summer 2027 • Southwest (Albuquerque, New Mexico)

Credits	3 graduate credits
Meeting schedule	Online asynchronous; live case workshops Thursdays, 6:00–7:00 p.m. MT
Location	Online learning platform
Delivery	Accelerated eight-week hybrid-synchronous online
Instructor	Dr. Sofia Ramirez, MPH, PhD
Email	sramirez@mvu.example.edu
Office hours	Virtual office hours Tuesdays, noon–1:00 p.m. MT
Prerequisite	Health systems fundamentals recommended

Course description

An accelerated graduate course in U.S. health policy analysis, emphasizing rural and frontier service delivery, Medicaid policy, tribal public health governance, telehealth, and health workforce shortages in the Southwest. Students assess policy alternatives and prepare decision-ready recommendations.

Learning outcomes

1. Define a policy problem using population health and systems evidence.
2. Map relevant decision-makers, institutions, and stakeholder interests.
3. Assess policy alternatives for effectiveness, equity, cost, and implementation.
4. Distinguish federal, state, tribal, and local roles in public health governance.
5. Produce an evidence-based policy brief and oral testimony.

CEPH-aligned MPH foundational competencies

The following course outcomes are mapped to selected MPH foundational competency themes used in CEPH accreditation. This is an illustrative course-level alignment, not a claim of institutional accreditation or an official CEPH-approved mapping.

- Discuss multiple dimensions of the policy-making process, including the roles of ethics and evidence.
- Evaluate policies for their impact on public health and health equity.
- Propose strategies to identify stakeholders and build coalitions and partnerships.
- Advocate for political, social or economic policies and programs that will improve health in diverse populations.
- Communicate audience-appropriate public health content.

Required and recommended materials

- Kraft, M. E., and Furlong, S. R. Public Policy: Politics, Analysis, and Alternatives (selected chapters).

- KFF state health facts and CMS Medicaid policy resources (online).
- Rural Health Information Hub policy briefs and selected peer-reviewed articles.

Additional readings, case materials, and datasets are posted to the learning management system at least one week before use.

Assessment and grading

Assessment	Weight
Weekly policy discussion memos (6)	20%
Stakeholder and governance map	15%
Comparative policy matrix	20%
Policy brief	30%
Recorded testimony	10%
Workshop participation	5%

Grading scale: A 93–100; A− 90–92; B+ 87–89; B 83–86; B− 80–82; C+ 77–79; C 73–76; F below 73. Graduate credit generally requires B− or better; consult program-specific rules.

Course schedule

Week	Topic / activity	Deliverable / milestone
1	Policy process and rural health problem definition	Issue selection memo
2	Rural and frontier access; stakeholder mapping	Stakeholder map due
3	Medicaid, financing, and coverage	Discussion memo 2
4	Tribal sovereignty and cross-jurisdictional policy	Comparative policy matrix draft
5	Telehealth, broadband, and workforce	Policy matrix due
6	Equity, ethics, and implementation feasibility	Policy brief outline
7	Writing recommendations and testimony	Draft brief peer review
8	Final policy workshop and synthesis	Policy brief and recorded testimony due

Schedule is subject to reasonable adjustments announced through the LMS; official university calendar dates and holidays govern meeting changes.

Course expectations and policies

Attendance and engagement: Students are expected to prepare for each class or module, participate respectfully, and contribute to group exercises. Notify the instructor in advance when possible about an absence or missed workshop.

Late work: Assignments submitted within 48 hours after the deadline incur a 10% deduction unless an extension was approved. Later submissions require instructor approval. Contact the instructor early about emergencies or accessibility needs.

Academic integrity and citations: Submit original work, acknowledge collaborators, and cite data, readings, software, and external materials. Fabrication, plagiarism, and unauthorized reuse of prior submissions are not permitted.

Accessibility and accommodations: Students seeking accommodations should contact the university accessibility office and the instructor promptly. Course materials and alternative participation arrangements can be discussed confidentially.

Professional conduct, data privacy, and AI: Students must distinguish tribal sovereignty and government-to-government relationships from state or county authority. Publicly available policy data may be analyzed; no confidential agency or patient information may be uploaded to external AI tools. Any AI-assisted drafting must be disclosed and fact-checked.

Student support: Library research assistance, writing support, technical help, and student wellness resources are available through university services. Consult the institutional student handbook for formal grievance, nondiscrimination, and appeal procedures.

SYNTHETIC SAMPLE — Fictional institution, instructor, and contact details. Not an official university syllabus.